RESERVE BANK OF MALAWI

OPENING REMARKS

BY

MR. FRASER MDWAZIKA

DIRECTOR, NATIONAL PAYMENT SYSTEMS DEPARTMENT

AT THE LAUNCH OF SENSITISATION CAMPAIGNS ON THE BUSINESS LICENSING REGULATIONS, 2019

BINGU INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE CENTRE

LILONGWE

16TH AUGUST 2022

The Guest of Honour, Dr. Wilson Banda, Governor of the Reserve Bank of Malawi

The Principal Secretary, Ministry of Trade, Mrs. Christina Chatima**

Executive Management and colleagues from the Reserve Bank of Malawi

The Chief Executive Officer, Bankers Association of Malawi and all Chief Executive Officers from commercial banks and mobile money operators present here

Delegates from the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises

Distinguished Guests

Ladies and Gentlemen,

First of all, I would like to welcome you all to this auspicious occassion. A special welcome to our **Guest of Honour, Dr. Wilson Banda, Governor of the Reserve Bank of Malawi**. Thank you Governor for taking time off your busy schedule to come and grace this very important event.

Today is a special day for all of us in the digital financial services arena. Having laid down the necessary “rails” following implementation of the payment systems infrastructural transformation program a few years ago, now is time to ensure that stakeholders that

are willing to transact digitally, do so with much ease. One way of achieving this is through the operationalisation of the Business Licensing (Deployment and Usage of Electronic Payment Channels) Regulations which came into effect in 2019 coupled with the awareness campaign which is being launched today.

The awareness activities being launched today, mark the continuation of RBM's engagements with the general public as well as the business community in sensitising all stakeholders about the availability and advantages of various forms of digital financial services in the country.

Our Guest of Honour, Distinguished Delegates, you will recall that the Reserve Bank of Malawi championed the establishment of the National Taskforce on Electronic Payments (NTEP) which draws its membership from a number of payment systems stakeholder institutions in the country. The establishment of NTEP was, among others, aimed at enabling a well-coordinated approach in the implementation of policy interventions geared at accelerating adoption of digital financial services in the country. The ultimate goal of NTEP, guided by the Reserve Bank, is to ensure that business entities as well as individuals, including those in rural areas, have easy access to digital financial services. Through such coordinated efforts, payment systems stakeholders strive to design products as well as implement measures that enable the populace, including the marginalised and low income earners, gain access to digital financial services, thereby enabling them participate in the formal financial services industry.

The Reserve Bank therefore continues to spearheaded implementation of awareness activities under NTEP through both the print and electronic media as well as physical engagements with the relevant stakeholders, which have so far yielded positive results, evidenced by the increase in both adoption and usage of digital financial services in the country.

As the world is going digital, we should not be left behind in this race. Malawi has what it takes to actively participate in this race and payment systems stakeholders are busy innovating day and night. **Our Guest of Honour, Distinguished Delegates**, evidence shows that we are indeed migrating from paper based payment arrangements, which were dominant in the pre-90 era, to digital. Such migration should therefore not only be by the large scale institutions but also the micro, small and medium enterprises as well as man in the street. But for us to achieve this, payment systems operators should design measures that make digital financial services a preferred option to cash or cheques.

Our Guest of Honour, Distinguished Delegates, all in all, the appeal from a cross section of payment systems providers in Malawi is simple: **"Go Cashless, Use Electronic Payments".**

I thank you for your attention.